

1840s-2021

VOTES FOR WOMEN

Women fought a long campaign to win the right to vote, especially in Britain and the US where the struggle was particularly intense. By the 1860s, women's suffrage movements – linked to women's growing demands for equality – were developing in the UK and US. These suffragists campaigned using respectable law-abiding methods, such as petitioning and lobbying parliamentarians, holding meetings, organizing marches, and writing to the press. However, as time went on, some – the suffragettes – turned more to direct action and civil disobedience to achieve their goals.

Campaigning faltered towards the end of the 19th century but was galvanized when New Zealand women won a right to vote in

1893. Australia followed in 1902 and four years later Finnish women won the vote – the first to do so in Europe. Most women gained the vote during the inter-war years, with some enfranchised following constitutional or revolutionary changes. Russia, for instance, extended the vote to women as part of the 1917 revolution.

Between 1893 and 2021, most of the world's women gained the vote but not always equally. Age, property ownership, literacy, or ethnicity could restrict rights. In Britain, only propertied women over 30 had the vote in 1918; equal rights had to wait until 1928. In South Africa and Australia, white women gained the vote before indigenous women and women of colour.



KEY MOMENTS

1893 Casting a vote

New Zealand women were the first to gain the vote in 1893; others, especially in the Middle East, had to wait longer. Kuwaiti women were able to vote in 2005 and Saudi women (*left*) in 2015 (in municipal elections only).

1903 Growing militancy

In the UK from 1903, suffragettes – members of the Women's Social and Political Union (WSPU) led by Emmeline Pankhurst (*left*) – turned to militancy. They rushed the Houses of Parliament, chained themselves to railings, and broke windows. About 1,000 suffragettes were imprisoned.

1917 Political participation

Women's access to political office came later than a right to vote. The first woman to be elected to the parliament of an independent nation was Jeannette Rankin (*left*), who entered the US House of Representatives in 1917. Today, many women are visible in the political arena but in fewer numbers than men.

